

“There was a severe dearth of open source professionals in India... but things are changing now”

“Open source professionals are at an advantage when it comes to hiring, simply because the demand for such skills is much higher than the supply,” says **Karthi Swaminathan**, *vice president, Site Operations and Engineering, CollabNet*, in an exclusive conversation with **Diksha P Gupta** from *LFY*.

If you are a professional with exposure to open source technologies, you are at an advantage. Sounds incredible?

Well, you have to believe it because companies like CollabNet are constantly looking for people with experience in open source technology. Explaining the advantage of open source skill sets, Karthi Swaminathan, vice president, Site Operations and Engineering, CollabNet, said, “I think people with exposure in open source technology have better engineering expertise. Being a part of an open source project adds value to their resume. They surely stand a better chance in getting selected over the others in a company like ours where open source technology is a major part of our business.”

CollabNet is one of the early adopters of open source technology. The company has sponsored the Subversion project, which is a very popular version control system used by millions of developers across the globe. Swaminathan said, “As consumers, we use a lot of open source technologies, be it Red Hat, JBoss or MySQL for our own product development, and they are part of what we build for customers as solutions.

Good open source professionals are hard to find

CollabNet is one of the many companies that hires professionals with experience in open source technology, year after year, but has found it a difficult task. Swaminathan said, “Few years back there was a severe dearth of open source professionals in India. I would say it was just one in every ten candidates we interviewed that we could hire. The number of people contributing to the open source community was very low. There were a lot of people who had tried or experienced open source as consumers but very few who actually contributed to open source technologies.” This was one of the major hurdle for companies that wanted to try projects using open source technologies.

At CollabNet, open source professionals are preferred over the others. Swaminathan adds, “If we have to hire for the engineering teams, we look for open source exposure in every hire. We are always glad to hire such professionals. I cannot quote the exact figures but I can confidently say that professionals with experience in open source technology are preferred over the others. If there are some very talented people without experience in open source technology, we encourage

them to get friendly with the technology when they come on board. We ensure that they get opportunities so that they can



Karthi Swaminathan,
vice president, Site Operations and
Engineering, CollabNet

grow in this direction.” But the market remains the driver in this case as well. Enterprises are adopting open source technology in a big way and hence there is a demand for open source professionals as well. “Some of the open source solutions fit the bill pretty well for many companies. Open source, by its very nature, attracts some of the best talent across the industry to contribute. So, basically, a mature open source product is a good option in terms of the issues it addresses and its technical soundness,” adds Swaminathan.

The scene is changing...

The consumers of open source technology are increasing but the number of developers is not growing at the same rate. Swaminathan explains, “The situation is much better than what it used to be five to six years back. If we look at the situation then, the talent available to contribute to open source was minimal and we were one of the pioneers in that space. But of late, things have changed. We are starting to see people contributing to various open source projects – and whether they do it as a part of their jobs or due to their own interest is immaterial.

There are people who have completely adopted open source as their career option, irrespective of their remuneration. They just want to contribute to open source society. People now know that by working on open source, they are working with the best minds across the industry. It gets them a lot of visibility and marketability.” Open source technology is becoming increasingly mainstream. A lot of great products have come out of the open source world and that clearly has attracted a lot of great talent. That, too, is contributing to the improving trend.

Open source is contagious

If you have an interest in open source technology, CollabNet provides you a perfect atmosphere to grow and live your passion. Swaminathan says, “We have renowned open source contributors working within the company. We also provide platform and programs for those engineers who are interested in learning and contributing to open source technologies, and a good number of open source committers have emerged that way, already.” 